Ultrasound Lets Scientists Check Coral Without Harming It

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Coral can now get a health check without being hurt. Scientists used an **ultrasound** machine, the same kind doctors use to look inside the human body, to look inside living coral under water and spot eggs growing within it. It is the first time they can check a coral's health without cutting it open.

Until now, checking for eggs usually meant cutting the coral open. The new way uses sound waves instead. Canon, the camera company, said this week that its medical **ultrasound** machine, the Aplio i700, can scan coral under water. With the group Coral Spawning International, the team scanned six kinds of large **polyp** stony coral and saw through their hard **skeletons**.

To be sure the scans were right, the team cut open one kind of coral, Trachyphyllia geoffroyi, and took close-up pictures of its inside. The pictures matched the scans, showing the shapes were really eggs.

Knowing when corals will release their eggs can help people who protect reefs plan their work and give **breeding** programs a head start. Coral needs help: late last month, the International Union for Conservation of Nature warned that 96 percent of Earth's coral reef systems face a very high risk of **collapse** within the next 50 years.

Word Treasure

ultrasound -- A machine that uses sound waves to make pictures of the inside of something.

polyp -- A tiny soft animal that builds coral.

skeletons -- The hard parts that give coral its shape and support.

breeding -- Helping animals have babies so there will be more of them.

collapse -- To fall apart and stop working as it should.

Background you need

Coral are tiny sea animals that build hard reefs where many ocean animals live.

An ultrasound machine uses sound waves to make pictures of the inside of something without cutting it open.

Scientists need to know when coral will release their eggs so they can plan how to help protect reefs.

Break it down

WHO: Scientists working with Canon and Coral Spawning International
WHAT: Used an ultrasound machine to look inside living coral and spot eggs without cutting it open
WHERE: Under water, inside living coral
WHY: To check coral health safely and help people protect reefs and plan breeding programs

Why it matters

Healthy coral reefs keep ocean animals alive and keep the sea beautiful for children to visit, explore, and learn about.

Test what you remember

1. What did scientists use to look inside living coral without cutting it open?

- (A) A hammer
- (B) An ultrasound machine
- (C) A magnifying glass
- (D) A fishing net

2. What did scientists spot growing inside the coral?

- (A) Tiny fish
- (B) Eggs
- (C) Small stones
- (D) New branches

3. How did the team check that the scans were right?

- (A) They drew a picture
- (B) They waited a year
- (C) They asked a doctor
- (D) They cut open one kind of coral, Trachyphyllia geoffroyi, and took close-up pictures of its inside

4. How many kinds of large polyp stony coral did the team scan?

- (A) Two kinds
- (B) One kind
- (C) Ten kinds
- (D) Six kinds

5. What did the International Union for Conservation of Nature warn?

- (A) That coral reefs are growing fast
- (B) That all coral is already gone
- (C) That coral needs warmer water
- (D) That 96 percent of Earth's coral reef systems face a very high risk of collapse within the next 50 years

6. Why does knowing when corals will release their eggs help?

- (A) It helps people catch more fish
- (B) It makes coral grow faster
- (C) It stops storms
- (D) It can help people who protect reefs plan their work and give breeding programs a head start

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: D 4: D 5: D 6: D

Questions to think about

1. International Union for Conservation of Nature: Warned that 96 percent of Earth's coral reef systems face a very high risk of collapse within the next 50 years.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):